



FROST DATES & SEASON

Last frost: April 15 – May 10
First frost: October 1 – October 20
Season: 150–180 days

THIS MONTH — MAY 2026

1. Transplant broccoli, cauliflower, cabbage, kale & onion starts outdoors mid-April — frost-tolerant and need to establish before heat.
2. Direct sow beets, carrots & succession lettuce through April — these are your spring harvests.
3. Start cucumbers, squash, pumpkins & melons indoors in late April (3–4 weeks before last frost). Don't start too early — cucurbits resent root disturbance.

QUICK-START CROPS

Dragon Tongue bush bean (H)
Direct sow after last frost. 57 days, no staking, high yield, great container performer.

Mortgage Lifter tomato (H)
80 days, large beefsteak, forgiving for beginners, full Zone 5 season with time to spare.

Lemon cucumber (H)
65 days, compact vine, prolific, less bitter than slicing types, great for small spaces.

STORAGE & PRESERVATION

- Two preservation windows: early summer (peas, greens — blanch & freeze) and late summer (tomatoes, peppers, beans).
- Tomato sauce is the highest-value project. A day of canning in August produces 18–24 quarts — 6 months of pasta sauce.
- Hot sauce fermentation uses peppers that ripen just before frost. Ferment 2–3 weeks, refrigerate — no canning needed.

ZONE
5

Central Corridor, Southern
New England, Mid-Elevation
West
Denver CO · Des Moines IA · Boston MA suburbs

HEIRLOOM VARIETY SPOTLIGHT

Mortgage Lifter tomato (H)
80 days, bred by M.C. Byles for home gardeners. Exceptionally large sweet pink beefsteak. Seed-saveable.

Dragon Tongue bean (H)
Yellow with purple streaks, 57 days, no staking. The variety that converts non-bean-growers.

Chioggia beet (H)
55 days, candy-stripe interior, dual-purpose (root + greens), grows in 12 inches of soil.